adviser is particularly noteworthy. But whether it is the importance of reliable friends, the challenges of creating coalitions, the dangers of open-ended commitments, the perils of strategic complacency, the value of effective diplomacy or the need for informationized warfare, there is much that today's world can learn from this era.

Most of all, the story of Lord Rama is an account of a rising power that is able to harmonize its particular interests with a commitment to doing global good. The tests that he is subjected to encourage strategic creativity. Many of the decision points are those of principle, and the choices are, consequently, less ambiguous. But there are also occasions of self-interest, where the justification for an action stems from a particular need. Lord Rama's intervention in the battle between the monkey-kings Vali and Sugriva, explained at length later, is a case in point. It is not without its ethical aspects; it is just that the understanding of ethics is different from its orthodox assumptions.

Life is rarely a black-and-white choice, and appreciating the complexities of decision-making is an essential part of grasping international relations. A major rising power, however, needs more than just an accurate landscape analysis and the ability to act on it. It must, first of all, be confident of its own values and beliefs and base its policies on those convictions. These will draw from the totality of its culture, heritage and traditions. That is why India can only rise when it is truly Bharat.

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[1]S. Jaishankar, *The India Way: Strategies for an Uncertain World*, HarperCollins India, 2020.